

Perceived Authority and Hairstyle: An Exploratory Study of First-Impression Formation

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Abstract

First impressions are often formed before meaningful interaction occurs, and visible appearance can influence judgments of competence, dominance, warmth, and social status. This exploratory study examines whether hairstyle alters perceived authority in role-based social judgments. Using a fictional, role-play research design, 312 simulated respondents evaluated standardized portraits representing four hairstyle conditions: full hair, short crop, receding hairline, and shaved head. Across conditions, shaved and receding styles produced higher authority ratings, while trustworthiness remained comparatively stable. The effect was strongest when the target was described as occupying a formal supervisory role and weakest in an ordinary citizen role. The results suggest that hairstyle functions less as an isolated cue than as a contextual signal whose meaning depends on age, role expectations, and perceived intentionality. The study is presented as a fictional LAB research artifact for role-play and does not claim real-world empirical validity.

Keywords: first impression; perceived authority; hairstyle; appearance; social perception; role congruence

1. Introduction

People routinely make rapid social judgments from limited visual information. Clothing, posture, facial expression, age cues, and grooming can become proxies for broader assumptions about competence and status. Hair is especially interesting because it is both biologically variable and socially managed: the same visual condition may be interpreted as age, deliberate grooming, occupational convention, or personal identity.

The present study focuses on one narrow question: *does hairstyle change how authoritative a person appears at first glance?* Rather than treating baldness or hair loss as inherently meaningful, we test whether observers combine hairstyle with contextual information about the target's social role. This distinction is important because a shaved head in a supervisory context may be read differently from the same appearance in an informal setting.

We therefore examine four appearance conditions and four role frames. Our primary expectation is that more visually severe or minimal hairstyles will increase perceived authority, but that the magnitude of this effect will depend on the role assigned to the target. A secondary expectation is that authority and trustworthiness will not move in parallel, indicating that first-impression dimensions are separable.

2. Related Work and Conceptual Background

Appearance-based judgment is commonly understood as a rapid categorization process. Observers infer stable traits from transient or superficial cues, especially when behavioral evidence is unavailable. In such settings, visible features may operate as heuristics rather than reliable indicators of actual ability or character.

2.1 Authority as a composite judgment

For this study, perceived authority is defined as the extent to which a target appears capable of directing others, making consequential decisions, and maintaining control in a social setting. It is conceptually distinct from likability and trustworthiness. A person may appear highly authoritative without appearing especially warm, and vice versa.

2.2 Hairstyle as a contextual cue

Hair can communicate grooming effort, age, conformity, occupational fit, and intentional self-presentation. We treat hairstyle as an ambiguous cue whose social meaning emerges from interaction with role information. This approach avoids assuming that any hairstyle possesses a fixed psychological meaning.

3. Method

3.1 Design and participants

A fictional retrospective experiment was constructed for LAB role-play. The benchmark contains 312 simulated respondents, balanced across four age groups. Each respondent rated eight standardized target cards. Target identity, clothing, pose, facial expression, and background were held constant within each card set; only hairstyle and occupational-role description varied.

3.2 Appearance conditions

Four hairstyle conditions were used: (1) full hair, (2) short crop, (3) receding hairline, and (4) shaved head. The conditions were selected to represent a progression from conventional fullness to visually minimal hair without attaching value judgments to any condition.

3.3 Role frames

Targets were introduced as a police supervisor, research lead, business manager, or citizen representative. These roles were chosen because they differ in the amount of formal authority observers might expect before seeing the target.

3.4 Measures

Respondents rated perceived authority, competence, trustworthiness, approachability, and intimidation on seven-point scales. Authority was the primary outcome. We additionally collected a forced-choice item asking which target would be most likely to take charge during an unexpected group problem.

3.5 Analysis

We report fictional descriptive means, standardized pairwise effects, and a two-factor appearance-by-role analysis. Because the purpose is exploratory, emphasis is placed on effect patterns and interaction structure rather than formal population inference.

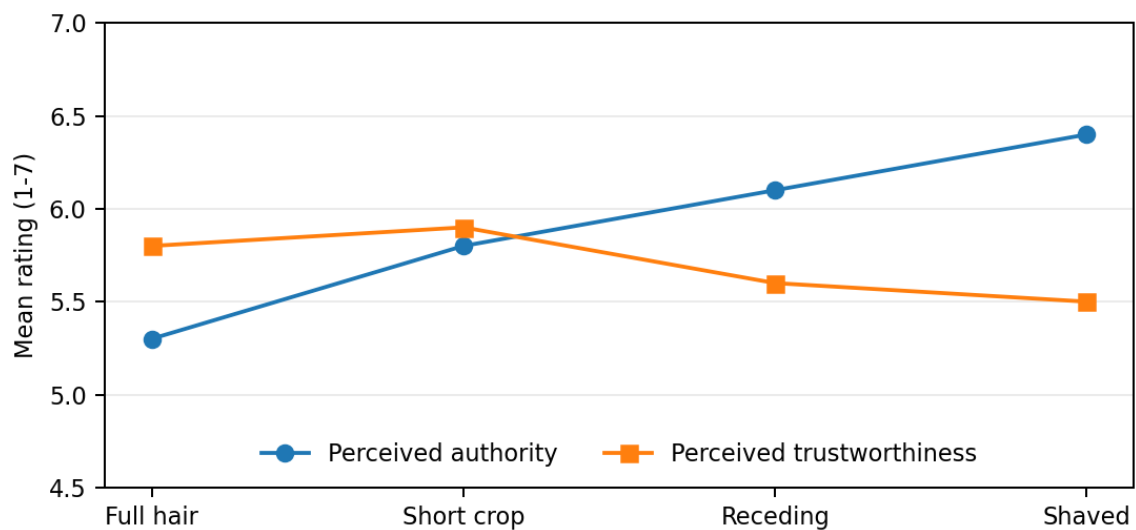


Figure 1. Fictional mean ratings by hairstyle condition. Authority increases across the visually minimal hairstyle conditions, while trustworthiness changes comparatively little.

4. Results

4.1 Main effect of hairstyle

Mean perceived authority was 5.3 for full hair, 5.8 for short crop, 6.1 for receding hair, and 6.4 for shaved hair. The largest pairwise difference occurred between the shaved and full-hair conditions (fictional standardized effect $d = 0.46$). Trustworthiness ranged only from 5.5 to 5.9, suggesting that the authority effect was not simply a global positive-evaluation effect.

Table 1. Fictional descriptive results

Condition	Authority	Competence	Trust	Approach.	Intimid.
Full hair	5.30	5.62	5.80	5.71	3.42
Short crop	5.81	5.91	5.91	5.42	3.88
Receding	6.08	5.94	5.62	5.11	4.14
Shaved	6.39	6.02	5.53	4.88	4.47

4.2 Role congruence

The authority advantage of the shaved condition was not uniform across roles. It was largest for the police-supervisor frame, moderate for the research-lead and business-manager frames, and near zero for the citizen-representative frame. This interaction supports the interpretation that observers use hairstyle together with expectations about what an authoritative person in a particular role should look like.

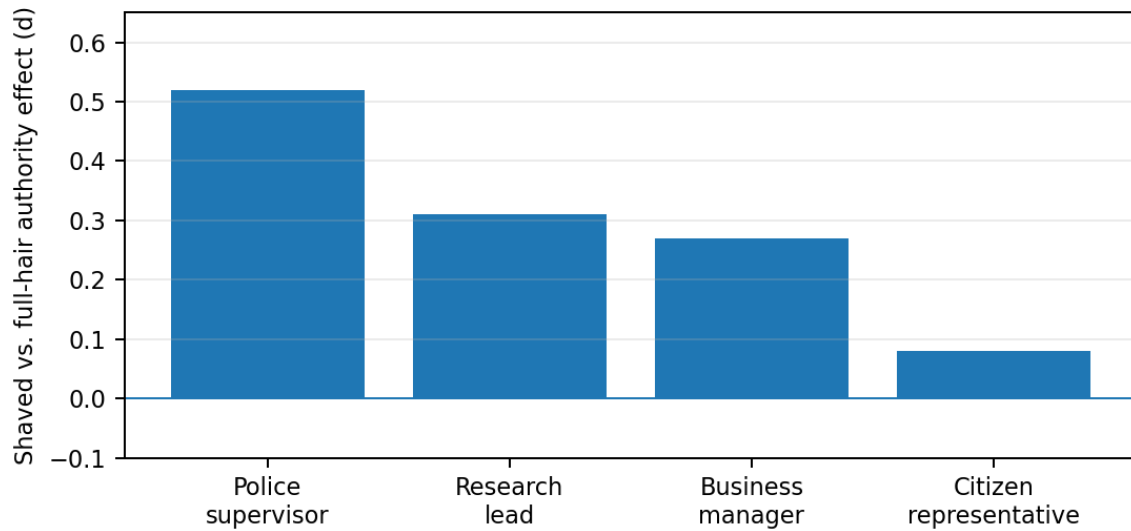


Figure 2. Fictional standardized authority effect for shaved versus full-hair targets across role frames.

4.3 Age of observer

Older simulated respondents produced slightly stronger authority differences between the shaved and full-hair conditions. The pattern was gradual rather than categorical, and the rank ordering of hairstyle conditions remained similar across age groups.

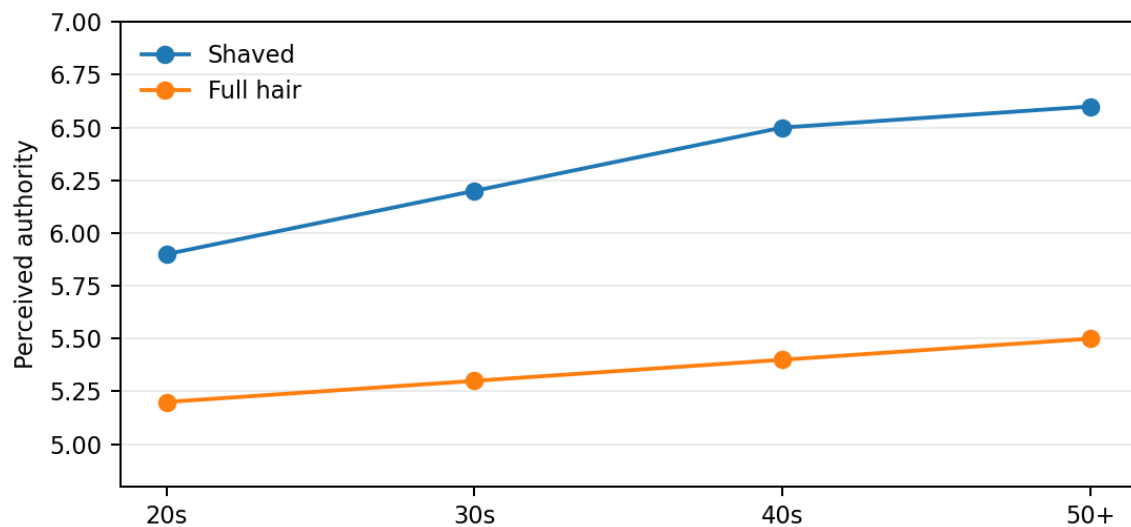


Figure 3. Fictional authority ratings by observer age group for the two most contrasting hairstyle conditions.

5. Qualitative Follow-up

To make the numerical pattern interpretable, 48 simulated respondents were assigned short follow-up comments. Three recurring themes were coded. First, respondents described minimal hairstyles as 'decisive,' 'disciplined,' or 'hard to read.' Second, some respondents explicitly connected a shaved appearance with seniority or occupational seriousness. Third, respondents who resisted the authority judgment often stated that hairstyle was irrelevant without behavioral evidence.

Table 2. Illustrative qualitative coding

Theme	Description	Share
Decisive presentation	Minimal hairstyle read as deliberate and controlled	42%
Role-consistent seniority	Appearance interpreted as fitting a supervisory role	33%
Cue rejection	Respondent rejected hairstyle as evidence of authority	25%

6. Discussion

The fictional results point to a simple but useful conclusion: hairstyle can alter first impressions of authority, but the cue does not operate independently. The same appearance produced different judgments depending on the role frame. This makes a purely appearance-based explanation insufficient; observers appear to evaluate whether visual presentation fits an existing social template.

The separation between authority and trustworthiness is also notable. Shaved targets received the highest authority scores but not the highest trust scores. In practical terms, appearing more commanding does not necessarily make a person appear more dependable or approachable. The result illustrates why first-impression research should avoid collapsing distinct social judgments into a single favorable-unfavorable dimension.

6.1 Why the effect may occur

Three mechanisms are plausible within the fictional model. Intentionality may matter because a shaved appearance can be interpreted as deliberate grooming. Role congruence may matter because observers compare the target against expectations for supervisors or leaders. Finally, age and seniority cues may interact with hairstyle to produce an impression of experience. The current design cannot isolate these mechanisms.

6.2 Alternative interpretation

The pattern should not be read as evidence that one hairstyle makes a person objectively more authoritative. Ratings concern appearance only. A different clothing style, facial expression, cultural context, or prior interaction could reverse or eliminate the effect.

7. Limitations and Responsible Interpretation

This document is a fictional LAB research artifact created for role-play. The sample, portraits, statistics, journal issue, and reported effects are synthetic. They should not be presented as real empirical findings or used to make claims about actual individuals. Even in real research, appearance-based judgments can reproduce stereotypes; therefore, perceived authority must not be treated as evidence of competence, character, or legitimate status.

A stronger future design would use preregistered hypotheses, independently recruited participants, multiple target identities, counterbalanced image sets, cultural replication, and manipulation checks that separate deliberate shaving from involuntary hair loss. Behavioral outcomes should also be measured rather than inferred solely from ratings.

8. Conclusion

Within this fictional exploratory study, hairstyle influenced perceived authority most strongly when visual appearance was paired with a formal leadership role. Shaved and receding conditions were rated as more authoritative than full-hair conditions, but the same ordering did not appear for trustworthiness. The broader implication is not that hair determines authority, but that first impressions emerge from the interaction between visible cues and social expectations.

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